

Jacques Offenbach was born in Cologne, Germany but at an early age settled in Paris and became a naturalized Frenchman. At the age of fourteen, he joined the orchestra of the Opera Comique as a cellist. He originated a rather individual style of comic opera known as *opéra bouffe* many of which, together with his ballet pantomime, were produced in his own theatre, the Bouffes-Parisiens. His greatest work, the *Tales of Hoffmann*, was produced after his death. The first performance was given in Paris, Feb. 10, 1881.

The poet Hoffmann and his student friends of Nuremburg, are making merry in the tavern while he tells of his three unhappy love adventures. The scene changes, Hoffmann is given a pair of magic glasses through which he sees Olympia, his first love, who is in reality a beautiful mechanical doll. He pleads to dance with her and they waltz so madly and rapidly that Hoffmann falls in a swoon. The glasses break and he learns that his love was an illusion. In the next act (in Venice), he discovers his friend, Niklaus, with a captivating lady, Giulietta, seated in a gondola, singing the "Barcarolle" in the mystic moonlight. He falls in love with her, fights a duel with his rival, and kills him but, to the bitter disappointment of Hoffmann, Giulietta elopes with another. He then goes to Munich and wins the heart of the lovely Antonia, a delicate singer with a wonderful voice, whose doctor warns her that if she sings she will bring on a fatal illness. The wedding of Hoffmann and Antonia is set for the next day. In her happiness she sings and falls lifeless in her father's arms. The "Tales" are ended, the students depart and Hoffmann, sad and lonely, is consoled by the Muse of Poetry.



Olympia, the Dancing Doll—Act I

Barcarolle from Tales of Hoffmann

Play with a swinging six-eighth rhythm to suggest a swaying gondola drifting under moonlight, a night in Venice.

Offenbach (1819-1880)

Moderato

The musical score is presented in four systems, each with a grand staff (treble and bass clef). The key signature has one sharp (F#). The time signature is 6/8. The tempo is marked 'Moderato'. The first system includes dynamic markings 'pp' (pianissimo) and 'mp' (mezzo-piano). Fingerings and articulations are indicated throughout the score.

First system of musical notation. Treble clef, key signature of two sharps (F# and C#). The right hand features a melodic line with triplets and slurs. The left hand provides a harmonic accompaniment with chords and single notes. Fingering numbers (1-5) are indicated above and below notes.

Second system of musical notation. Continuation of the piece. The right hand has a more active melodic line with slurs and ties. The left hand continues with a steady accompaniment. Fingering is clearly marked throughout.

Third system of musical notation. Dynamic markings *mf* (mezzo-forte) and *p* (piano) are present. The right hand shows a sequence of chords and moving lines. The left hand has a more rhythmic accompaniment. Fingering numbers are visible.

Fourth system of musical notation. Dynamic markings *p* (piano) and *cresc.* (crescendo) are present. The right hand features a melodic line with a crescendo. The left hand has a harmonic accompaniment. Fingering numbers are visible.

Fifth system of musical notation. Dynamic markings *poco rit.* (poco ritardando) and *a tempo mp* (allegretto moderato) are present. The right hand has a melodic line with a *poco rit.* marking. The left hand has a harmonic accompaniment. Fingering numbers are visible.

4 2 1 4 2 1 5 2 1 4 2 1 R.H.

5 2 1 5 3 2

5 2 1 5 3 2

5 3 2 1 2 3

5 3 2 1 2 3

5 2 1 4 2 1